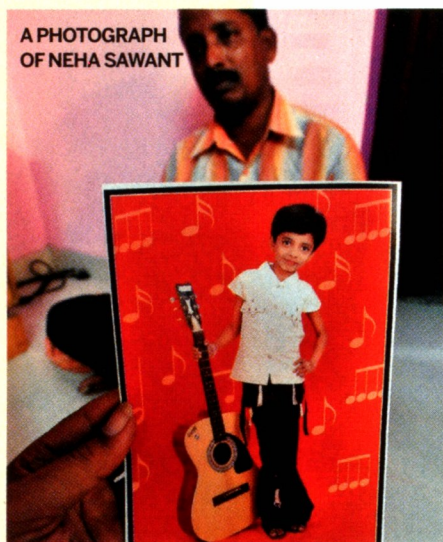


MUMBAI | Snuffed Hopes



A PHOTOGRAPH OF NEHA SAWANT

The pressure even on the most young to succeed in a career is taking a cruel toll. Within three days, Mumbai woke up to three ghastly cases of suicide by the very young. While two, Sushant Patil, 12, and Bhajan Preet Kaur, 18, chose to end their lives after failing in their examinations, 11-year-old Neha Sawant hanged herself to death after being prevented from participating in dance reality shows by her parents. Johnson Thomas, director of Asara, a 24-hour helpline for the distressed, says the number of callers for emotional support rises sharply during the examination and result-declaration season in schools and colleges. Many involved in such helplines believe that tragedies such as the recent three arise due to lack of intimate communication between today's parents and their children. **by Mitali Patel**

SHIMLA | Fruit for Thought

HIMACHAL'S APPLE FARMERS MAY NOT WANT TO LISTEN TO ISRAEL'S ANSWERS TO CULTIVATION ISSUES.

Himachal Pradesh Chief Minister Prem Kumar Dhumal plans to replicate Israel's success in apple cultivation in his state. "With no snowfall and much lesser rain than us, they produce 50 tonnes of apple per hectare. We produce one-fifth of it," he says. Apple production dropped almost to half in the last season while prices rose to around Rs 100 per kg. The state produced over 255 lakh apples in 2008, but less than 135 lakh in the last season. The apple growers may not want to listen to Israel: after all, last year they put in less labour but got better returns. **by Arvind Chhabra**

UTTARAKHAND WILL SPEND RS 350 CRORE ON THE KUMBH MELA.

UTTARAKHAND | Dip Test

The Kumbh Mela in Haridwar, starting January 14, will be a litmus test for the BJP Government headed by Chief Minister Ramesh Pokhriyal Nishank. Since its creation in 2000, Uttarakhand will host the biggest congregation on earth for the first time. With more than 10 crore pilgrims are expected to attend the festival, Nishank is personally monitoring all arrangements. Over 10,000 police and para-military force personnel have already been deployed. But the bigger challenge is to foil possible acts of terrorism. Nishank says the state is "likely to spend Rs 355 crore" on security arrangements and regulating pilgrim flows. **by Subhash Mishra**



A HOLY DIP IN HARIDWAR

BANGALORE | Clean Trip

Walking the talk is well known but a Karnataka bureaucrat Bhaskar Rao decided to pedal his way to spread his eco-friendly transport message. The commissioner of the state transport department, 45-year-old Rao completed a 900-km, eight-day ride to the Nilgiris along with enthusiasts of a pro-cycling Bangalore group. Says the Lance Armstrong fan, "Cycling is the best way to beat traffic congestion and stay fit, especially in cities like Bangalore." Rao wants to work with the traffic police to get cyclists back on the road, introduce cycle lanes and give the city the feel of an Amsterdam or a Beijing where cyclists are ubiquitous with their presence. But he also wants the city to ensure all cyclists that they will always be safe on their two wheels. **by Stephen David**